



Payback time: Amanda Anisimova turned the tables at the U.S. Open, producing a hard-fought quarterfinal upset to avenge her stunning double-bagel loss to the Pole at Wimbledon.

just trying to emulate the way she trusts her game and the way she goes after it," Keys told *Eurosport*.

For seven straight matches at a Major, Keys proved Down Under that she could perform like that too. Even more impressive, the 22-1 pre-tournament long shot beat four top-10 opponents to equal an Open Era record. In the third and fourth rounds, Keys overpowered No. 10 Danielle Collins 6-4, 6-1 and No. 6 Elena Rybakina, a former Wimbledon champion, 6-3, 1-6, 6-3. During the match with 28th-seeded Elina Svitolina, Keys volleyed superbly, winning 23 of 26 net points, to overcome her in a 3-6, 6-3, 6-4 quarterfinal test.

The Sabalenka-Keys final posed two intriguing questions. Would Keys follow the game plan of all-out aggression or succumb to nerves? Could she become the first woman since Serena Williams in 2005 to defeat the top two seeds at the Australian Open? Yes and yes.

Serving at 5-6 in the deciding set, Sabalenka blinked first with three unforced errors. Keys seized her chance and blasted a forehand winner on championship point.

Both cried — the loser covering her tears of anguish under a towel and the winner shedding tears of joy and relief. "It means the world to me," Keys told the cheering crowd. "I have waited for this for so long."

Crediting her own team for her first Grand Slam crown in her 46th Major appearance, Keys said: "They believed in me when I didn't believe in myself."

Sabalenka wasted no time in getting her mojo back, winning her first Miami Open by overpowering Collins, Zheng Qinwen, Jasmine Paolini, and Jessica Pegula in straight sets. "Aryna has the technique, she has all the shots, she volleys well, she has topspin so she can whale away at the ball. She's relentless," said Navratilova. "Where are you going to attack her?"

See-saw of fortunes

Gauff answered that critical question at Roland Garros.

The No. 2 seed from Florida boasted the best foot speed and defence on the Tour, but her offence sputtered at times. Gauff, a teen queen who won the 2023 U.S. Open at 19, eased into the quarterfinals, where she defeated Keys 6-7(6), 6-4, 6-1, despite 10 double faults and 40 unforced errors. At just 21, that made her the youngest American to reach back-to-back Roland Garros semifinals since 1982.

The dream final featured No. 1 Sabalenka's power versus No. 2 Gauff's mobility. In the dramatic, fluctuating opening set, Gauff staved off two set points to break for 5-all. She then led 4-1 and 5-3 in the tie-breaker. But the hyper-aggressive Sabalenka retaliated with four straight booming winners — two backhands, a stinging forehand volley, and a feathery forehand drop volley — to clinch it 7-5.